

GREAT ZIMBABWE



ONE OF AFRICA'S GREATEST archaeological mysteries is the walled city of Great Zimbabwe. This massive granite zimbabwe – a word literally meaning chief's court – was begun in the 13th century. By the 14th century, it had become the capital of a vast kingdom that stretched between the Zambezi and Limpopo rivers. The people of Great Zimbabwe were mainly farmers, but the city was also the main centre for trade and religion. However, by 1450, Great Zimbabwe had been abandoned for reasons that remain a mystery. Today its ruins stand in modern Zimbabwe, the southern African country named after this remarkable walled structure.

Great Enclosure

Built of massive granite blocks, the Great Enclosure is a huge dry stone wall that surrounded the city, providing protection for Great Zimbabwe's people. Inside the enclosure, people lived in circular houses made from daga (a gravel-like clay) and roofed with thatch. There were also small oval enclosures – but, like the stone conical tower, their purpose remains a mystery. Near to the enclosure was a hill complex, which was used for religious rituals.

The conical tower was 9 m (27 ft) high, and made of solid stone.

Farming

Great Zimbabwe at its height had 10,000 people living in and around it. Most people were farmers in the surrounding areas. They herded cattle and grew millet, sorghum, and vegetables, which they sold to the many traders visiting the walled city.



Zimbabwean cattle

Karl Mauch

A German self-taught geologist, Mauch (1837–75), travelled southern Africa from 1865 to 1872. During his nine months in Great Zimbabwe (1871) he drew diagrams of the ruins and sketched the carved stone and metal objects found there. Much of today's knowledge of the area is based on Mauch's diaries.



Ancestor worship

The people of Great Zimbabwe worshipped the spirits of their dead rulers, known as ancestors. In sacrificial rites, they killed calves, and offered the meat to ancestor spirits on beautifully carved soapstone dishes. They placed the dishes in sacred places outside the hill complex.

Birds

Eight carved soapstone birds have been found at Great Zimbabwe. They stood in sacred places on 1-m (3-ft) high soapstone columns. Each of the birds may represent a royal ancestor, and one of them is now used as the symbol of the modern state of Zimbabwe.

Soapstone bird on column



Timeline

c.900 Iron Age (Shona) people settle between the Zambezi and the Limpopo rivers in southern Africa.

1100s Trade passing through Great Zimbabwe to Africa's East Coast increases.

1200s Zimbabwean gold being exported to Asia.

1250 Building in stone begins at Great Zimbabwe.

Early 1400s Great Enclosure is completed; and Great Zimbabwe reaches its greatest extent.

1450 Great Zimbabwe is abandoned, probably because its people leave to look for new and better farmland.



Rise of Great Zimbabwe

Great Zimbabwe's first city started as a farming settlement, possibly as early as the 2nd century. As well as rearing and selling cattle, its people mined for gold and copper on the Zimbabwe plateau. By the 12th century, long-distance trade based on gold and copper was passing through the city from the east coast of Africa. As Great Zimbabwe rose in importance and wealth, it was rebuilt in stone and increased in size.



Hill complex

Hill complex

The religious centre, where the ancestors' spirits were worshipped, was built on a hill near the Great Enclosure. At the front of the complex, there was a public space where the mambo (ruler) conducted sacred rites.

Conical tower

A massive and mysterious cone-shaped tower stands inside the Great Enclosure. Some archaeologists think it may be a monument celebrating the power and wealth of the rulers of Great Zimbabwe.



Trade

The prosperous trading centre of Great Zimbabwe was situated on one of the trade routes that linked southern Africa to the east coast. Traders from Sofala and Kilwa (in modern Mozambique) obtained gold and copper from Great Zimbabwe to export to Arabia and Asia.

Metal exports

The people of Great Zimbabwe mined gold, copper, iron, and tin on the Zimbabwe plateau. Cross-shaped ingots were exchanged for trade goods from Asia, such as beads, glassware, and ceramics.



Copper ingot

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